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OPERATION 'HARDBALL': 37 CHARGED IN U.S. INDICTMENT

Nijjar killing: US charges Bishnoi, Brar; no India govt link: Canada

Dept of Justice: 24 linked to 3 Indian crime syndicates held in coordinated action by US, Canada & Europe

Divya A & Shubhajit Roy
New Delhi, July 8

ALMOST THREE years after the then Canadian prime minister Justin Trudeau alleged a "potential link" between Indian government agents and the killing of pro-Khalistan figure Hardeep Singh Nijjar, bringing bilateral ties to a standstill, the US has charged gangster Lawrence Bishnoi and aide Goldy Brar with ordering the assassination. Later, Canadian police said there was "no evidence" of any official involvement from India in the killing.

The latest twist in the Nijjar case came after a US-led operation against three criminal gangs involved in transnational crimes, including one led by Bishnoi (33) who is lodged in a Gujarat jail.

The two other gangs indicted by the US Department of Justice (DoJ) include one headed by Jaggu Bhagwanpuria (38) from Punjab, a Bishnoi associate-turned-rival who is lodged in an Assam jail, and another led by Canada-based Ravinder Singh Dhanda (57).

Called "Operation Hardball", the coordinated action by law enforcement from the US, Canada and Europe was announced on July 8.

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Officers conduct a raid in southern California as part of 'Operation Hardball'. REUTERS

E. EXPLAINED

Long-term effect

Canada's statement on the Nijjar killing removes a major irritant in bilateral ties with India. The joint US-Canada-Europe operation also signals deepening international cooperation against Indian-origin gang networks spanning continents and entangling members of the Indian diaspora.

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CANADIAN SCRUTINY TO FBI'S OP: HOW NET TIGHTENED AROUND LAWRENCE BISHNOI

'New Zealand, working with India, needs to remake case for a rules-based system'

Shubhajit Roy
New Delhi, July 8

NEW ZEALAND Prime Minister Christopher Luxon says he is confident of the strength and potential of ties between his country and India, as Narendra Modi arrives in Auckland Friday for the first visit by an Indian Prime Minister to New Zealand in four decades.

In an exclusive interview with *The Indian Express*, outlining economic, defence, security, and people-to-people ties as the three pillars of India and New Zealand ties, Luxon set this against the "inflection point" in global geopolitics where the world has moved from "a rules-based system to a power-based system, a multilateral system to a multipolar system".

"We see an America that is talking America first with a fix-

EXPRESS
interview



CHRISTOPHER LUXON
NEW ZEALAND PRIME MINISTER
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ation on the Western Hemisphere. We see China wanting to have influence in our Indo-Pacific region. We also see Russia illegally invading a sovereign nation in Ukraine and wanting to dominate in Europe, and so it's natural that there is a real inflection point," Luxon said.

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INDIAN EXPRESS UPSC IAS EDITION HD 09~07~2026

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[FROM PAGE 1 | FULL REPORTS ON WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM]

Nijjar

Canada and Europe led to the arrest of 24 people connected to three Indian crime syndicates, now charged with a series of crimes including Nijjar's assassination, the DoJ said Wednesday.

Members of the three gangs have been charged with targeted killings, shootings, extortion and narcotics trafficking across borders, offences carrying up to life imprisonment, the DoJ said.

In Ottawa, RCMP Deputy Commissioner Lisa Moreland told CBC News: "There is no evidence to suggest that through this organised crime syndicate investigation and the charges laid forward that Indian government officials would be charged or involved in this... nothing has come out to link the Indian government."

Nijjar, a Canadian citizen, was shot dead outside a gurdwara in Surrey, British Columbia, on June 18, 2023 -- a killing that ruptured ties between New Delhi and Ottawa after Trudeau's allegations. India's Ministry of External Affairs rejected the allegations as "absurd and motivated" and "baseless".

The fallout saw diplomats withdrawn, visa restrictions imposed and consulates shut for nearly two years. After Mark

Carney became Canada's Prime Minister last May, both sides worked to insulate bilateral ties from the Nijjar investigation, reinstating envoys, lifting visa curbs and setting a new trade target.

A separate US indictment

had earlier linked Nijjar's killing to the attempted murder of Khalistani separatist Gurbhag Singh Pannun in New York, through intercepted communications and shared targets. In February, Indian national Nikhil Gupta pleaded guilty in US federal court to murder-for-hire and conspiracy charges in the Pannun plot.

The US indictment on Tuesday said Bishnoi ordered the killing of 45-year-old Nijjar, referred to as "HSN" in court documents. While Bishnoi is lodged in Sabarmati Central Jail, the FBI has announced a \$50,000 reward for information leading to the arrest of Satinder Singh alias Goldy Brar and is likely to seek Bishnoi's extradition.

In all, 37 people were charged in the indictment. Those arrested in the US -- 11 in California, one each in Indiana and Georgia -- were expected to make initial court appearances later Wednesday. Ten fugitives are being sought, including seven in the US, two in India, one in Europe.

The DoJ noted an indictment is merely an allegation: "All defendants are presumed innocent until proven guilty beyond a reasonable doubt in a court of law." If convicted, many of the 37 face a mandatory minimum of 10 years, up to life imprisonment.

The action follows a years-long investigation into Indian crime syndicates engaged in racketeering, targeted killings, extortion and narcotics trafficking whose impact is felt especially in the Indian diaspora, the DoJ said.

"Transnational criminal gangs who spread fear, drugs, and violence will face the full

force of justice and the weight of the federal government," said First Assistant US Attorney Bill Essayli. "Working together, law enforcement in the US, Canada, Europe, and Asia are determined to target and dismantle these criminal organisations wherever they operate. There is no safe harbour for these thugs," he said.

It is believed that law enforcement agencies in India also collaborated with the investigators on the case.

According to the US DoJ, Bishnoi had delegated control to trusted lieutenants: Brar as North American leader; Rohit Godara (37), of Rajasthan as European leader; and, Sukhraj Singh Kang (58) of Punjab. They extorted victims via WhatsApp and other encrypted apps by threatening violence against them or their families, the DoJ said. Canada designated the Bishnoi enterprise a terrorist entity in September 2025.

The RCMP said in a statement: "Today, together with the Federal Bureau of Investigation (FBI) Los Angeles, we announced several arrests and charges against the leaders of three global organised crime networks: Lawrence Bishnoi, Ravinder Dhanda and Jaggu Bhagwanpuria. These groups have been engaged in extortions, drug trafficking, kidnapping and widespread violence -- namely the killing of Hardeep Singh Nijjar -- in Canada and the United States."

The statement said that the RCMP "played a pivotal role in today's outcomes", calling it "a big moment" for the force "and for public safety in Canada, the

United States and around the world". The arrests and search warrants worldwide were the result of "combined efforts of Canadian and American law enforcement over the past two years," the RCMP said.

While most of the arrests occurred in the US, three individuals from British Columbia were taken into custody on Provisional Arrest Warrants, with extradition to follow even as three search warrants were executed in West Vancouver, White Rock and Surrey.

"Tuesday's coordinated operation strikes at the heart of three brutal transnational organisations that have terrorised families, exploited communities, and stolen lives through ruthless acts of violence in the US and abroad," said Patrick Grandy, FBI Los Angeles Assistant Director-in-Charge.

The second gang, run by Bhagwanpuria, had 17 members charged with murder-for-hire, drug and weapons trafficking, kidnapping and extortion in the US and Canada.

This group corrupted law enforcement officers in India and partnered with corrupt government officials, including to assist in extortion schemes, the DoJ said while referring to the case of Punjab Police officer Gurinderjit Singh, who allegedly engaged in extortion activities on behalf of the gang.

The indictment charged the gang run by Dhanda of Vancouver, and 10 others, with running a drug distribution network smuggling bulk cocaine and methamphetamine to trafficking organisations in the US, Canada and Mexico.

New Zealand PM

"The benefit for a country like New Zealand," he added, "is that as a free trader, as a small country, since World War II, we have been a huge beneficiary of the rules-based system, because small countries are treated the same as large countries, and big ones don't bully little ones."

This is where the relationship with Delhi comes in, Luxon said. "New Zealand, working with India and other like-minded friends, needs to remake the case for a rules-based system." He also backed the demand for reform in this, agreeing with the Indian view. "In many cases, the Global South countries of India and

Brazil haven't really been part of that system that was created after World War II, and so we need to remake that case," Luxon said.

About the bilateral ties between India and New Zealand, he said: "We've been friends for over 100 years, we actually are at different ends of the Indo-Pacific region and haven't really had a lot that actually binds us together to drive a future agenda. Prime Minister Modi and I have talked about these two countries that actually have a very similar view and a very similar set of values and actually should be doing more together and should have a much broader and deeper

relationship."

On immigration opportunities for Indians in New Zealand, especially given the changed environment in the US, Luxon said: "We see it as a huge opportunity. All around the world you're seeing countries and democracies in the West react with an anti-immigrant bias and sentiments. That creates opportunity for New Zealand because it means that talented folk who may have headed to the US can now reappraise our educational institutions. We are an English-speaking country, we have an advanced economy, we are a very safe country, and importantly, we have very good educational institutions. We have been very welcoming of Indians to New Zealand on a number of levels."

On why New Zealand is not seeing anti-immigrant sentiments, the PM said: "First and foremost, New Zealand has legal immigration, not illegal. Secondly, we have smart, fair, and targeted principles by which we manage it, anchoring our immigration settings in our economic settings, where we have skill shortages, and in infrastructure. We have the capacity to make sure people are set up for success when they come to this country, that there is sufficient housing, schooling, roads, hospitals."

Luxon has been the New Zealand PM since 2023 and visited India in March last year. He also visited the country back in the 1990s while working with Unilever.

Modi will be in New Zealand on July 10 and 11.

**Nirbhay Thakur &
Abhimanyu Hazarika**
Gurgaon, July 8

GMDA Chief Executive Of-



GAJENDRA YADAV

According to Meena, among the locations where the interventions proved particularly effective were AIT Chowk, St. Xavier's School Junction, Tulip Chowk, Medanta Road, Artemis Hospital Road, Rezang La Chowk, Sector 22/23, and Sector 45/46 Road.

“Ponds in Palra, Dhanwarpur, Darbaripur, Tulip Chowk, and Khedki Majra successfully accumulated 10-12 feet of rainwater, aiding groundwater recharge and reducing drainage pressure. Permanent drainage improvements yielded significant relief in previously flood-prone areas, including Rajendra Park, Surat Nagar, Sector 17, and wards 30 and 32. Despite 87 mm of rainfall in some areas, effective storm-water management and active field teams...ensured smooth water discharge,” it stated.

INDONESIA VISIT CONCLUDES

Modi lands in Australia, to meet Albanese today

Strengthening Indo-Pacific ties, Quad on agenda

Shubhajit Roy
New Delhi, July 8

A DAY after he landed in Melbourne, Prime Minister Narendra Modi will meet Australian Prime Minister Anthony Albanese on Thursday for the third annual summit, where they are expected to discuss co-operation in the Indo-Pacific region, critical minerals and education partnership, among other areas.

Ministry of External Affairs spokesperson Randhir Jaiswal said, “PM Modi lands in Australia. PM @narendramodi arrived in Melbourne to a warm and special welcome.” He said Modi will co-chair the summit with Albanese and engage with stakeholders to further deepen the India-Australia Comprehensive Strategic Partnership across all sectors of mutual interest.

Modi posted on X, “Landed in Melbourne, Australia. This visit will add vigour to the India-Australia Comprehensive Strategic Partnership. I look forward to the talks with Prime Minister Albanese. I will also have the opportunity to interact with the Indian diaspora, which is an important pillar of our partnership.”

This is the PM’s third visit to Australia; he is visiting Melbourne after a gap of 12 years.

The geopolitically significant visit is expected to boost India’s MAHASAGAR (Mutual and Holistic Advancement for Security and Growth Across Regions) and Indo-Pacific vision. “It will further cement ties between two QUAD partners who are playing greater roles in the Indo-Pacific, bringing new opportunities and prosperity for people and countries, especially the Small Island Developing States,” officials said.



PM Narendra Modi and President Prabowo Subianto at Prambanan Temple in Indonesia, Wednesday. PTI

Modi, Prabowo launch project to conserve Indonesia temple

Divya A
New Delhi, July 8

PRIME MINISTER Narendra Modi, before concluding his Indonesia visit on Wednesday, visited the 9th-century Prambanan Temple complex in Yogyakarta along with Indonesian President Prabowo Subianto to inaugurate a joint conservation project for the UNESCO World Heritage Site. The project will be led by the Archaeological Survey of India (ASI).

Calling the initiative a “shining example of the enduring civilisational bonds” between India and Indonesia, the two leaders also unveiled a plaque at the temple, marking the commencement of the ASI’s conservation and restoration project at the site.

“President Prabowo Subianto and I inaugurated the UNESCO World Heritage Prambanan Temple Compound Restoration and Conser-

vation Project,” Modi posted on X after his visit. “The magnificent Prambanan Temple stands as a timeless symbol of our cultural and spiritual links. Preserving such heritage is about safeguarding the traditions that continue to inspire generations,” he said, adding India is privileged to partner with Indonesia in this important endeavour.

The central focus of the project is the restoration of the Perara temples — 224 subsidiary shrines arranged in four concentric rows within the middle zone of the compound, official sources told *The Indian Express*. Of these 224 temples, only six have been restored to date and the remaining 218 stand as extensive ruins.

The project, spanning 10 years, till 2036, with a total outlay of Rs 65 crore, will be executed by ASI in collaboration with the Indonesian Heritage Agency, sources added. The key activities of the project include LiDAR

(Light Detection and Ranging) sensor, and photogrammetric documentation of scattered stone members, archival research, structural, hydrological, and geotechnical studies.

“As nations with deep cultural connections, India and Indonesia will continue to work together to celebrate our shared past while building an even stronger future,” Modi said.

“As we begin the conservation and restoration work at Prambanan Temple complex, I am very assured that Indian tourists will definitely visit this place,” he added.

The Prambanan Temple Compound, inscribed a UNESCO World Heritage Site in 1991, is among the most magnificent ensembles of Hindu temple architecture in the world. Built in the 9th century under the Mataram Kingdom in Central Java, the compound contains over 500 temples, including the soaring 47-metre Shiva temple.

FROM CANADIAN SCRUTINY TO FBI'S OPERATION HARD BALL

How net steadily tightened around Lawrence Bishnoi

Manraj Grewal Sharma
Chandigarh, July 8

THE NET around jailed gangster Lawrence Bishnoi's alleged international crime network has tightened steadily over the past two years, with Canadian law enforcement agencies leading the way long before this week's FBI-led Operation Hard Ball.

From being publicly identified by the Royal Canadian Mounted Police (RCMP) in 2024 to being designated a terrorist entity by Canada and now facing sweeping US indictments, the Lawrence Bishnoi gang has come under mounting international scrutiny as investigators on both sides of the border closed in on its alleged operations in Canada. The latest indictments name Bishnoi and his close associate Satinderjeet Singh, alias Goldy Brar, for crimes allegedly committed on Canadian soil.

The Canadian authorities first referred to the Bishnoi gang on October 14, 2024. During a nationally televised RCMP press conference on alleged foreign interference and criminal activity in Canada, Assistant Commissioner Brigitte Gauvin identified the Bishnoi group, saying investigators believed it was being used to target pro-Khalistan activists in Canada.

Though then the remarks were connected to the June 18, 2023 killing of Khalistani separatist Hardeep Singh Nijjar outside the Guru Nanak Sikh Gurdwara in Surrey, British Columbia, an incident that had plunged India-Canada ties into a diplomatic crisis, it was the spate of extortion-related shootings that had prompted the RCMP to investigate the Bishnoi link.

One of the prominent cases involved Abjeet Kingra, 26, and Vikram Sharma, 24, who were



Seized evidence presented at a news conference at the Federal Building in Los Angeles on Tuesday. AP

accused in a Surrey extortion-linked shooting case that led investigators to the Bishnoi gang. Kingra was arrested in October 2024 and later pleaded guilty to arson and firearms offences committed, according to court records, "at the behest of the Bishnoi gang".

Investigators also linked Kingra to the September 2024 shooting at the Colwood, British Columbia, residence of Punjabi singer AP Dhillon. Authorities alleged that Kingra filmed the attack using body-camera style footage and uploaded it online so that the Bishnoi gang could claim responsibility. Investigators said the attack was allegedly carried out in retaliation for Dhillon featuring Bollywood actor Salman Khan in one of his music videos, and that Kingra was paid about 4,000 Canadian dollars for the job.

Sharma is believed to have fled Canada and is suspected to be in India. During deportation proceedings in June this year, Kingra claimed the gang had threatened him and his family in India because it believed he had cooperated with investigators. However, Canada's Immi-

gration and Refugee Board ordered his deportation after concluding that he was a member of a criminal organisation.

By mid-2025, the focus had shifted sharply to organised extortion targeting South Asian businesses, particularly in British Columbia. These incidents became frequent enough to attract political attention.

On June 17, 2025, British Columbia Premier David Eby announced that he would formally request the federal government to designate the Lawrence Bishnoi gang a terrorist organisation, saying repeated incidents of violence and intimidation were eroding public confidence in the justice system.

The demand gathered momentum after Abbotsford Police received a letter in August 2025 purportedly from the Bishnoi gang claiming it had "1,000 foot soldiers" ready to carry out shootings across Canada as part of its extortion operations. The letter later surfaced during proceedings before Canada's Immigration and Refugee Board, where an Edmonton police investigator cited it as evidence of the gang's reach and its at-

tempts to intimidate victims.

Canada's financial intelligence agency, FINTRAC, also flagged money laundering linked to extortion networks operating in the gang's name. It pointed to a pattern in which business owners in Greater Toronto and Metro Vancouver first received threats and were then asked to make large payments.

On September 29, 2025, Canada formally listed the Bishnoi Gang as a terrorist entity under the country's Criminal Code.

Announcing the decision, Public Safety Minister Gary Anandasangaree said the government had concluded that the organisation had "knowingly carried out, attempted to carry out, participated in or facilitated terrorist activity" through murders, shootings, arson, extortion and intimidation that had created "a climate of insecurity" within South Asian communities.

The RCMP investigations took a cross-border turn when a victim who moved to Canada after helping Indian law enforcement identify and arrest two suspected blackmailers began to receive death threats from a California resident identified as Jasmeet Singh. Later the US authorities charged him with making the threats on behalf of the Bishnoi gang.

In one documented case from the Sacramento FBI office (December 2023), Bishnoi himself allegedly contacted a victim whose vehicle was later fired upon outside his home.

In January this year, Global News reported details from a classified RCMP national security assessment describing the Bishnoi organisation as "a violent criminal organisation with an active, continually expanding presence" in Canada and several other countries.

EXPRESS special

2 warnings, zero action: Why Wayanad tunnel tragedy is a 'man-made disaster'

Nikhila Henry
Hyderabad, July 8

BETWEEN JUNE 20 and 25, the Kerala government administration issued two warnings to the contractor of the Anakampoyil-Kalladi-Meppadi tunnel project, Bhopal-based Dilip Buildcon, stating that soil piled up from tunnelling should be removed from the site.

First, the district collector of Wayanad Meghashree D R, on June 20, wrote a letter stating that work at the twin tunnel project near Meenakshi area of Kerala's Wayanad district should stop temporarily, until the soil is removed.

"The order was not considered, and the construction company went ahead with the tunnelling work," Kerala's environment minister Sunny Joseph had told The Indian Express hours after the tragedy, which killed three and left several others injured. Five people are missing. "This is a man-made disaster because the warning was ignored. We are seriously looking into the lapses that put lives in danger."

On June 25, a high-level del-



Officials carry out a search and rescue operation at the site of the landslide in Wayanad on Wednesday. PTI

egation led by the Public Works Department inspected the tunnel project site along with officials of the District Disaster Management Authority, the State Environment Impact Assessment Authority, and the Konkan Railway Corporation, which is the executing agency for the tunnel project. PWD told Konkan Railway Corporation (KRCL) to reduce the height of the pile on the same day, the minutes of the meeting released by the PWD after the disaster show.

The pile posed a risk of soil piping and slope instability, ac-

cording to minutes of the meeting released by the PWD. The retaining wall and tarpaulin covering built by the contractor were not considered adequate protection against water seepage, the minutes reveal. Dilip Buildcon was asked to stop work at the site on June 27.

A PWD official told *The Indian Express*, "The district administration had identified land near the construction site for the soil to be moved there. There were two standing instructions in this regard." The project had generated one lakh cubic meters

of soil, the PWD had found. The soil was not removed because the corporation had not found "suitable land to keep it", sources close to KRCL claimed. The KRCL did not respond to requests from *The Indian Express* seeking a response.

Meanwhile, the contractor of the project, Dilip Buildcon, said what happened in Wayanad was a "natural calamity". "The incident occurred during an active monsoon spell, amid exceptionally heavy rainfall in Wayanad. The India Meteorological Department had issued warnings for heavy to very heavy rainfall across parts of Kerala, while preliminary data from the Kerala State Disaster Management Authority indicates that Wayanad received approximately 265 mm of rainfall in the preceding 24 hours - among the highest recorded in the district this monsoon season..." it said.

"Having said that, the project is being executed in strict compliance with all applicable protocols. Given its location in an ecologically sensitive region, the project is subject to multiple regulatory oversight and monitoring mechanism..." it said.

‘All around the world, you see anti-immigrant bias. New Zealand has strong social licence for immigration. Indians are hugely respected’

As Prime Minister Narendra Modi arrives in New Zealand on July 10-11, New Zealand PM Christopher Luxon tells *The Indian Express* that the two countries share similar views and values, and should be expanding their relationship. In an exclusive interview, PM Luxon speaks about India-New Zealand bilateral ties, trade and defence, dealing with pro-Khalistan elements in the Indian diaspora, the challenge posed by China in the Indo-Pacific, and US President Donald Trump. Excerpts:

What are the major outcomes you are hoping for from this visit?

When you take a step back and think about the New Zealand-India relationship, we have been friends for over 100 years, are actually at different ends of the Indo-Pacific region, but we haven't really had a lot that binds us together to drive a future agenda. We have huge respect for the Indians here in New Zealand. The Indian diaspora is almost 7% of our total population and is hugely successful across all strata of life, as it is around the world, and so I'm really excited. As a young person who spent most of my career with Unilever – we had Hindustan Lever in India – I spent a lot of time in India, and just the progress of this great country has been phenomenal... Prime Minister Modi and I have talked about the two countries having very similar views and values, and how we should actually be doing more together and have a much broader and deeper relationship.

So there are three legs to it. One, how do we continue our economic relationship through the Free Trade Agreement (FTA), which is of mutual benefit, and lift the living standards of both our peoples. The second piece is how we can do more together in a security and defence setting as well. We started some of that work when I visited last time, with our navies working together, but there's a lot more that I'd like to see, with joint exercises, more interactions between our respective defence forces. The third thing is people-to-people connections...

During your visit to India last year and meeting with PM Modi, a decision was taken to start FTA negotiations, and the treaty was concluded in April this year. How was this accomplished in such a short time, and what can the people of India and New Zealand expect to gain from this FTA?

We were able to move so quickly because of high levels of trust. I have huge respect for PM Modi, we have a very strong relationship, and it's likewise for Trade Minister (Piyush) Goyal with my Trade Minister (Todd) McClay. The four of us were really determined to drive it (the FTA) and make sure our systems didn't get lost in bureaucracy and the process, but... to deliver an FTA that would lift the living standards of both peoples.

If you think about our economies, they are quite complementary. Take technology, the smart that exist within India are huge. New Zealand is the best agricultural country on earth, and is now the third biggest launcher of rockets into space. We are building a very good technology sector as well, and are big on renewables... There are lots of things that we can share about our experience in that space, as well as things we can learn from India...

Obviously dairy is something we don't have full access to. It's very important to the Indian economy, and I understand the sensitivity around it, but we have applied a huge amount of R&D to proteins within our dairy sector that are very specialised niche products that are not available in India... We have got massive opportunities with things like apples and lamb... Equally, I want to see growth in our services agreements. We've got some outstanding technology companies that have their bases in India. We'll see more investment into India from New Zealand companies, and expect vice-a-versa...

Everything in life comes back fundamentally to a relationship, and PM Modi and I have a strong relationship... We enjoy each other's company. We're very aligned about what we're here to do as leaders.

One of the coalition partners in your government, New Zealand First, led by your Foreign Minister Winston Peters, is opposed to the FTA. How do you assuage concerns about the durability of the deal on account of this?

I can reassure you about that. We have a mixed-member proportional system... think of it like the governments of Western Europe. There are six parties in our Parliament, with a centre-left and centre-right party the dominant ones. Even though on opposite sides, they are fully supportive of

Ahead of Narendra Modi's visit to New Zealand, the first by an Indian PM in four decades, Prime Minister CHRISTOPHER LUXON speaks to SHUBHAJIT ROY on the bilateral trade agreement, shifting geopolitics, China and the US, and the potential to shape the future of the India-New Zealand partnership



New Zealand Prime Minister Christopher Luxon with Prime Minister Narendra Modi at Hyderabad House in New Delhi during the former's official visit to India in March 2025. PM Luxon was accompanied by a high-level delegation, including ministers, senior officials and business leaders.

the FTA with India, as are many of the four minor parties. The party you are referencing is one of the four minor parties, and they have always opposed every FTA that New Zealand has ever done, right back to the China FTA in 2008.

So that's not a surprise for us... Rest assured this (the FTA with India) will clear Parliament... In New Zealand, trade between major parties is a bipartisan issue, it's not something that we politicise... It's a New Zealand thing, it's something that's in the interest of all of us to make it work.

One of India's major concerns is China's assertive, often aggressive, behaviour in the Indo-Pacific. How do you see this Chinese threat perception?

There's no doubt about it, we're at an inflection point in global geopolitics. We are moving from a rules-based system to a power-based system, a multilateral system to a multipolar system. We see an America that is talking America first with a fixation on the Western Hemisphere. We see China wanting to have influence in our Indo-Pacific region. We also see Russia illegally invading a sovereign nation in Ukraine and wanting to dominate in Europe... As a free trader, as a small country, since World War II, we have been a huge beneficiary of the rules-based system, (where) small countries are treated the same as large countries, and big ones don't bully little ones...

That's why New Zealand, working with India and other like-minded friends, needs to remake the case for a rules-based system. It definitely needs reform, because in many cases, the Global South countries such as India and Brazil haven't really been part of the system created after World War II... It's not fully determined yet that it has to be a power-based system versus a rules-based system, but we do need to remake the case for it and reform the rules-based system. That's where working with India is so important, and that's why I'm a big believer of having multi mini-lattice work of many lateral arrangements, whether that



be around trade or defence...

When I was in India, we had our frigate up there working with the Indian Navy, they were working on missions together. So there's more that we can do in that space. We need to work with our like-minded friends to build a lattice of relationships... As we've seen in the world, you cannot have prosperity without security, and vice-a-versa. An attack on Iran from the US and Israel has caused huge amounts of pain and suffering to people all around the world...

US President Donald Trump has brought in a fair amount of unpredictability in geopolitics and the global system. How do world leaders like you deal with this?

It's about understanding and appreciating history, because we were here in 1918 (towards the end of World War I), in 1945 (end of World War II), in 1989 and the collapse of the Cold War and the (Berlin) Wall, and since 2022, with Russia's invasion of Ukraine... We've been here in what has increasingly become a power-based system.

I think there are two things you do: you de-risk by working together with like-minded friends with similar values and interests, and you get very clear in your relationships, where you say I will cooperate where I can, I will differ where I must... We have a huge, longstanding, very successful relationship with the US, but we also have fundamental differences around tariffs. We are a free-trading country that has had zero tariffs since the late 80s, and we believe very strongly that tariffs are just not the right economic recipe for the world.

We've seen that movie, and we don't think it ends well.

Now, we can disagree with the Americans around that, we raise it with them, but we still find areas to collaborate and cooperate on... and then work with other like-minded (countries)... (We can) get the EU and CPTPP countries (Comprehensive and Progressive Agreement for Trans-Pacific Partnership, including Australia, Brunei, Canada, Chile, Japan, Malaysia, Mexico, New Zealand, Peru, Singapore, the United Kingdom and Vietnam) working together because there's a huge amount of global trade in that. We brought the EU and ASEAN trade ministers together...

India has been concerned about the presence of Sikh separatist, pro-Khalistan elements in the Indian diaspora, including in New Zealand. How do you assuage those security concerns and balance them with the freedom of speech argument?

We fully acknowledge that the Khalistan issue has caused a huge loss of life and pain and suffering to people across India. We fully respect India's sovereign and territorial rights, and yes, we're a liberal democracy. But we have what we call rights and responsibilities, and so yes, you have the right to freedom of expression and freedom of speech, but accompanying that is a responsibility not to incite violence, intimidate others, denigrate others.

Our police make an assessment and are very alert, very alive, constantly monitoring to make sure that people are holding up both ends of that deal, because a liberal democracy only works if you appreciate rights and responsibilities... Also, as New Zealand and India deepen our relationship, we need to be able to sit down and talk about our assessment of terrorism across the region, and in a bilateral and multilateral way.

You are a partner in Five Eyes, the intelligence-sharing alliance that also comprises the US, the UK, Canada and Australia. What do you

think is the scope of collaboration between India and New Zealand when it comes to countering terrorist threats?

Those are areas where we can collaborate more on. It's how we work with many of our European, Southeast Asian and Pacific partners. We share a lot of intelligence with each other about risks and threats and extremism...

There is a lot of interest in India about education and job opportunities in New Zealand, particularly as US policies have put up barriers in the same. Do you see your immigration policies as geared towards welcoming Indians to New Zealand?

We see it as a huge opportunity. All around the world you're seeing countries and democracies in the West react with an anti-immigrant bias and sentiments. That creates opportunity for New Zealand because it means that talented folk who may have headed to the US can now reappraise our educational institutions. We are an English-speaking country, we have an advanced economy, we are a very safe country, and importantly, we have very good educational institutions. We have been very welcoming of Indians to New Zealand on a number of levels.

In fact, India is our second biggest source of visas already, and we've seen a huge growth in our international education market, up 11% in just the last 12 months. The trick, as I observe is, that first and foremost, New Zealand has legal immigration, not illegal. Secondly, we have smart, fair, and targeted principles by which we manage it, anchoring our immigration settings in our economic settings, where we have skill shortages, and in infrastructure. We have the capacity to make sure people are set up for success when they come to this country, that there is sufficient housing, schooling, roads, hospitals...

I think that's why New Zealand has a very strong social licence for immigration, because we have always anchored it, under successive governments. That's where other democracies have gone wrong...

The Indian community that has come to New Zealand has left everything behind for a better future. They work incredibly hard. They take two or three jobs to get a deposit for their house or their business. They get their kids to school and value education, and they never go on welfare. And they are hugely respected in New Zealand. Now they are highly successful in all strata of our life... So, it's an opportunity to make sure we bring the best and the brightest to New Zealand, share those people-to-people connections, form relationships, and (discuss) possibilities about what they can do together, whether it be in the research space, the business space, the community space...

First as a top business executive and then as PM, you have seen India from afar, as well as in close interactions. How do you see India's trajectory?

It's so exciting. I joined Unilever, and we had a very big business in India called Hindustan Lever, a top 10 company in India in its own right. So I started going to India in my 20s, and I remember going to what was a low-income country, I think, at the time, probably the 10th or 12th biggest economy in the world... I remember meeting people and workers that were paid in coins each day, put in their hands... Now you look at it and you see 450 million people in the middle class. By the end of this decade, you know what will be 750 million people living in the middle class. That's so exciting, because in the spirit of our relationship, when people have more money, they want higher quality diets and more protein, they want to have an educational experience and set their kids up for even more success. They want to travel because they can now afford to do so. They want to save some money for retirement and for their pensions, and so that needs to be invested.

And that's just a huge opportunity for both our countries. It's a country I admire tremendously. I'm a huge fan of what PM Modi has done. We think very similarly, we're very action outcomes-oriented leaders, and that's why it was very easy for us to move quickly through the FTA conversation, open up defence conversations and other things that we want to do together...

My wife Amanda and I have often talked about how eventually, when I retire from politics, to get onto your great railway service and travel the country from top to bottom and east to west for three to four months. It would be absolutely fantastic to get all of the dynamism, optimism, ambition, aspiration, positivity that exists in India. It's a great, great country! Yeah, fantastic country!

EXPRESS special

10 yrs after Burhan, how Kashmir’s militancy landscape has changed

Numbers are indisputable: In 2016, the year after photos of Burhan and his group emerged on social media, 157 militants were killed in Kashmir. This number peaked at 266 in 2018. This year, it’s down to 10

Bashaarat Masood
Srinagar, July 8

ON JULY 1, 2015, a picture of 11 young Kashmiri militants, dressed in camouflage, carrying Kalashnikov rifles and posing in a forest, appeared on Facebook. At the centre was Burhan-uddin Wani, who, shedding anonymity unlike militants before him, chose to broadcast himself and his group on social media and went on to operate in the Valley’s urban areas, particularly south Kashmir.

The images would draw several educated, tech-savvy young men from well-to-do families to follow in Burhan’s footsteps, opening a new chapter in Kashmir’s fight against insurgency and leading to a crisis not seen since the 1990s.

The killing of Burhan in a gunfight on July 8, 2016, triggered protests that shut Kashmir for over three months. As young protesters took to the streets and clashed with police, 55 were killed and thousands injured, with the violence in turn fuelling more recruitments. Many announced they were joining militant ranks publicly, at funeral processions.

Exactly 10 years later, the landscape in the Valley stands decisively transformed, with every key militancy indicator, from the number of active militants to fresh local recruitments to militant attacks and killings, showing a sharp decline.

The numbers are indisput-

•Casualties in Numbers

YEAR	MILITANTS KILLED	SECURITY FORCES KILLED	CIVILIANS KILLED
2016	157	88	56
2017	217	83	54
2018	266	94	88
2019	160	78	42
2020	230	57	37
2021	192	45	36
2022	186	30	30
2023	85	32	11
2024	68	26	32
2025	46	17	28
2026	10	1	1

able: In 2016, the year after the social media photos first emerged, 157 militants were killed in Kashmir. This number peaked at 266 in 2018 and saw another uptick to 230 in 2020. So far this year, it stands at 10. The number of security forces and civilians killed is also down – from 94 and 88 in 2018, respectively, to just one each this year.

On Wednesday, the killing of Zakir Ahmad Ganaie, a Lashkar-e-Taiba terrorist, in a gunfight in south Kashmir’s Shopian means that only one active local militant is now believed to be operating in Kashmir as per police records. The number of foreign operatives, security officials say, hovers around 30.

Top-ranking security officials emphasise the need for caution. “As a civilian, you see peace, the dividends of peace – the attacks have declined, killings have fallen, and the number of arrests and FIRs have come

down. But from the perspective of a security officer, the challenge remains,” says a key anti-insurgency police officer.

The shift – online and offline

On ground, officials say, the insurgency landscape has shifted from towns and cities to dense, mountainous forests of the Valley. On social media, the focus is back on anonymity, with communication sparse and an emphasis on leaving little or no footprint. “Even though a large number of operations were always based on HUMINT (human intelligence), the TE-CHINT (technological intelligence) helped corroborate and pinpoint locations with more precision,” says a senior police officer. “It also helped us understand the evolving dynamics of insurgency and how they operate, communicate and what they were up to.”

Less online chatter means security forces have little TE-CHINT to rely on now, the officer adds. “There may be fewer terrorists left, but they have gone silent. The insurgency has become more opaque, harder to penetrate, and harder to track.”

Security officials also emphasise that the “Burhan model” was an aberration rather than a sustainable template for insurgency. “He may have used social media to lure a large number of youth, but look at the rate at which they were killed,” says another police officer involved in anti-militancy operations. “It took them four years to realise that it is unsustainable.”

Another reason behind this retreat, security officials say, is the government’s crackdown after the abrogation of Jammu and Kashmir’s special status in 2019, on the terror support system and separatists, with critics accusing it of extending this to any voices of dissent.

“Post 2019, terrorism and support to terrorism have come at a huge cost. The government has gone after terrorists as well as people seen as supporting them,” says another official. “This has helped reduce support to terrorists and prevented fresh recruitments to a large extent. It has also forced the movement away from villages to forests.”

Security officials say another key shift is the takeover of “command and control” by Pakistani operatives. “After 2019, the Hizb (Hizbul Mujahideen) was almost

wiped out, and Lashkar took the centre stage. They are highly trained, resilient and well equipped. They operate from areas with a tactical advantage, such as high-altitude jungles. The command and control has increasingly shifted to these Pakistani operatives of Lashkar, which is seen as close to the Pakistani establishment. This means that militancy is more subservient to Pakistan now,” an officer says, adding that they remain aware that Pakistan too may be just biding time, after Operation Sindoor.

The BJP, which was part of the coalition government with the Peoples Democratic Party (PDP) in 2016 when Burhan was killed, credits the sharp decline in militancy to the change of leadership in J&K after the abrogation of special status. “The main reason is a leadership with resolve,” says BJP spokesperson Sajid Yousuf. “Also, there are no regional forces to interfere in police action. Before the abrogation, we had the same police force but there was political interference.”

The people of the Valley are equally to be credited, Yousuf adds, underlining that “there are no protests or stone-pelting now”. “People have realised the importance of peace and backed it. The enemy may be up to something, but our agencies have their eye on militant sympathisers, whether in a university or any other place. They are acting against them.”

KARNATAKA HIGH COURT HAS SOUGHT A RESPONSE FROM THE CENTRE

Gift or income? Same-sex couple’s gold bracelet sparks tax law challenge in HC

Mustafa Plumber
Bengaluru, July 8

WHEN IS a gift from your partner just a gift — and when is it “income from other sources”?

For same-sex couples in India, the answer currently turns on a single, undefined word in the Income Tax Act: “spouse.” And now, a Bengaluru couple has taken that word to court.

The Karnataka High Court on Tuesday sought a response from the Central Government on a writ petition filed by Anurag Kalia and Akhilesh Godi, both IIT alumni, who have challenged the Constitutional validity of the “fifth proviso” to

Section 56(2)(x) of the Income Tax Act, 1961. The provision exempts gifts between “spouses” from tax but a plain reading, or the literal meaning of the term in legal parlance, excludes same-sex couples.

The dispute began with a 22-karat gold bracelet weighing 14.41 grams. Godi, who had received it from his father as a family heirloom, gifted it to Kalia on the anniversary of their relationship. The couple declared the bracelet’s estimated value as Rs 1,15,500.

As per Section 56(2)(x), any money or property worth more than Rs 50,000 received without consideration is taxable as “income from other sources”. The proviso carves out gifts re-

ceived from a “relative” — a term the Act defines, for an individual, to begin with the “spouse of the individual”.

Had the two men been a married couple, or even an unmarried heterosexual couple presumed to be married by virtue of long cohabitation, the bracelet would not have counted as income at all, and would not even have had to be disclosed in a tax return.

Instead, while preparing his returns for 2025-26, Kalia was advised that he must have the bracelet valued by a registered valuer, report its fair market value as income, and pay tax on it at 25%, plus a 15% surcharge and 4% cess, according to their petition.



Karnataka High Court

The petitioners, who work as software engineers in Bengaluru, told the court that they have been together for more than seven years -- cohabiting

since 2019 with a jointly owned house in the city. The petition also states that they seek neither recognition nor presumption of marriage, nor any

declaration of marital status.

A line of decisions, dating back to a 1927 ruling by the Privy Council in *A Dinohamy v. Balahamy*, holds that if a man and woman are proved to have lived together as husband and wife for a prolonged period, the law will presume they are validly married, rather than partners lacking full legal rights and inheritance privileges. The plea by Kalia and Godi also cited Supreme Court rulings, as recent as 2023 in *Smt. Shiramabai v. OIC Records*, to argue for recognition of their relationship.

They argued that a heterosexual couple in the petitioners’ circumstances would therefore qualify as “spouses”, and hence

“relatives”, under the tax exemption. The petitioners argued that they are denied the same benefit “solely on the basis of sex”, in violation of Articles 14 and 15 of the Constitution, with consequent violations of Articles 19(1)(a) and 21, by taxing “an expression of love and affection”.

In a landmark ruling in 2018, the Supreme Court had held that “sex” under Article 15 includes sexual orientation.

Justice B M Shyam Prasad, who briefly heard the matter in the Karnataka High Court, narrowed the case to a single issue: when the legislature has chosen not to define “spouse”, can a court enlarge the term’s

scope through judicial interpretation?

“We intend to hear only on this aspect. If the enactment says the receipt in the hand of these only would not be income from other sources, how do we say it is discriminatory? The moment we say it is discriminatory, a door is open,” the court said in an oral observation.

The court also asked whether the definition’s meaning or scope could be extended to relatives of any kind: “There could be foster sons or foster daughters.”

A similar challenge to the provision, filed by Payio Ashiho and his partner Vivek Divan, is also pending before the Bombay High Court.

• DEFENCE

The significance of Astra missiles, which Indonesia will purchase

Amrita Nayak Dutta
New Delhi, July 8

INDIA AND Indonesia on Tuesday reached a significant milestone in their growing strategic cooperation by signing a deal for the supply of the Astra Mk 1 'beyond-visual-range air-to-air missiles' (BVRAAM).

Beyond-visual-range missiles are those capable of engaging beyond the range of 20 nautical miles, or 37 km. Air-to-air missiles are primarily fired from an airborne asset to destroy an airborne target.

The development is significant as it marks India's first export of Astra missiles to another country. These missiles will arm Indonesia's Su-30 fleet.

The missile and its variants

Developed by the Defence Research and Development Organisation, Astra is a family of indigenous BVRAAMs that will be integrated with the Air Force and the Navy.

The first in the family, Astra Mk 1, has a range of 80 to 110 km, an altitude of up to 20 km and a speed of Mach 4.5 (or 4.5 times the speed of sound).

MISSILE EXPORTS

- The India-Indonesia pact marks the first export of Astra missiles to another country.
- India is also set to supply the BrahMos supersonic cruise missiles to Indonesia, as well as to Vietnam and the Philippines.

A more advanced version — the Astra Mk 2 — has an enhanced range of 200 km, from the earlier decided range of around 160 km. This missile variant was granted the Acceptance of Necessity by the Defence Acquisition Council in December, indicating the government's interest in starting the procurement process soon, even as it is still in various phases of testing. They will also be integrated into the latest fighter jets of the IAF once inducted.

The Astra Mk 3 is still under development by the DRDO. Officially named Gandiva, it will be India's most advanced BVRAAM. It will likely be powered by a Solid Fuel Ducted Ramjet (SFDR) engine, allowing it to maintain continuous thrust mid-flight rather than burning out like conventional rocket motors.

Earlier this year, the DRDO had conducted a flight test of its SFDR technology for the Astra Mk 3, which could have a range of over 350 km.

A key part of the arsenal

The missile will be a counter to the long-range PL-15 in use by both Pakistan and China. The PL-15 is an advanced, very long-range, active radar-guided air-to-air missile developed by China.

Operation Sindoor, launched by India against Pakistan last year, demonstrated the criticality of longer-range BVRAAM missiles — and Astra is India's indigenous answer to that. A key focus area of the IAF is now to procure more batches of modern BVRAAM missiles. The Astra programme will help India build greater self-reliance, instead of depending solely on other imported air-to-air missiles such as the Meteor and R-77.

• GEOPOLITICS

Why US & Iran may keep trading blows amid talks



EXPERT EXPLAINS
BASHIR ALI ABBAS

SENIOR RESEARCH ASSOCIATE, COUNCIL FOR STRATEGIC AND DEFENSE RESEARCH, DELHI

US PRESIDENT Donald Trump said Wednesday that the interim ceasefire with Iran was "over" after a flare-up of hostilities between the two countries, although he added that he would allow negotiations to continue. He warned of targeting Iran again.

Iran targeted US military sites in Bahrain and Kuwait after US forces struck Iranian targets in response to attacks on tankers in the Strait of Hormuz.

The same pattern of attacks was also seen on June 26 and June 27 — Iran preventing transit through the Strait of Hormuz for commercial ships that did not coordinate with it, the US Central Command bombing Iranian targets and Iran hitting US bases in Bahrain and Kuwait.

This familiar cycle of escalation has threatened the shaky ceasefire between the two countries and jeopardised negotiations to turn the June 17 memorandum of understanding (MoU) into a lasting peace deal.

While Trump's comments have increased this uncertainty, he left a window open by saying that US representatives can continue negotiations. But he added: "They can talk, but I think they're wasting their time." Although Trump has at times stepped back from threats he has made against Iran, oil prices surged and stocks fell after his latest remarks, *Reuters* reported.

These exchanges between the US and Iran are an immediate effect of the differences over the Strait of Hormuz's future administration. But that's hardly the only factor at play here.

The Strait of Hormuz question

Under Article 5 of the MoU — which Trump has now declared "over" — the long-term administration of the Strait of Hormuz is to be determined jointly by Oman and Iran, "in line with applicable international law and the sovereign rights of coastal states of the Strait".

By June 23, Iran and Oman jointly declared the creation of a working group "to



Funeral prayers for Ayatollah Ali Khamenei in Qom, Iran on Tuesday. AP

Widening gulf

Oman, Qatar and Saudi Arabia's engagement with Iran has affected their ties with the US.

• A recent *Wall Street Journal* report indicated a downturn in US-Saudi ties. This was due to Riyadh's refusal to back Washington's failed military effort in early May to re-open the Strait of Hormuz.

Strait of Hormuz. So, even as the long-term future of the strait is clear, the short-term is not. Iran's sensitivities over any attempted new route (however temporary) draw from the Strait of Hormuz's new value as its main instrument of leverage. This will have to be reconciled with Washington's preference for unhindered passage during the 60-day negotiation period.

Iraq and Lebanon

While the short-term nature of this Hormuz-focused difference can theoretically ensure that US-Iran military clashes do not become a permanent feature, it is clear that a severe lack of trust with the US necessitates continual Iranian assertion to ensure that Washington does not deviate from MoU terms until negotiations for a final deal begin. Central to this is Washington's need to shape regional developments enough in the short term to ensure that Iran's long-term gains (beyond Hormuz) are curtailed. The volatility this creates is evident across regional states.

In Iraq, for instance, both the US withdrawal and Iran's entrenched presence through the Popular Mobilization Forces creates fresh ground for long-term Iranian influence. Washington, however, can still leverage Baghdad's need to sustain its ties with the US, as was witnessed during US Envoy Tom Barrack's June 15 visit to Iraq where he pressed new Iraqi premier Ali al-Zaidi to act against Iran-linked armed

groups. By June 28, during Iranian Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi's Iraq visit, Baghdad conducted unprecedented simultaneous midnight raids on at least 47 senior politicians and leaders, several of whom have close ties to Tehran and the PMF.

Similarly, in Lebanon, while Iran's need to ensure Israeli adherence to the ceasefire remains, the June 26 Framework agreement ties Israeli withdrawal to Hezbollah's disarmament — which the group continues to categorically reject, in light of Israel's continued occupation of South Lebanon. The Lebanese government's assent to the deal despite its lack of effective enforcement abilities leaves Lebanon in a volatile predicament where recurring Israeli strikes could further reduce trust in US-Iran technical talks, as has already occurred before.

What to make of the strikes

The recurring strikes are driving up the distrust between Tehran and Washington in the 60-day period, even though both appear committed to negotiating a final deal.

Gulf states themselves have already begun adapting to the new regional order.

Qatar, for instance, announced on June 18 that it was operationalising (and enhancing) a 2022 agreement that seeks to link Iran's South Pars and Qatar's North Field gas reservoirs. This can give Iran a transmission capacity of up to 1,000 megawatts from Qatar's electrical grid.

And Saudi Arabia is reportedly preparing to host a "Gulf-Iran reconciliation summit". This will expand the space for Iran's reintegration with Gulf economies.

Oman, Qatar and Saudi Arabia — unlike Bahrain, Kuwait and UAE — are looking to contain the Iranian threat through engagement and reconciliation, a path reinforced by what is widely agreed to be a strategic defeat for the US and Israel in the war.

Iran feels that the US will respond to its increased regional heft by repeatedly attempting to undermine its gains. This, in turn, would be something that Tehran would necessarily have to counter. This dynamic could trigger both intermittent military skirmishes before any final deal is reached, as well as a return to full-scale war.

Hence, this period of uncertainty may continue to witness more rounds of limited strikes, hostile rhetoric, mutually destructive threats and seemingly categorical assertions related to the long-term US-Iran relationship. In effect, however, they are likely to be focused principally on weakening the short-term negotiating position of the other side.

• INFRASTRUCTURE

Indira Point: Inside the plan to protect lighthouse, develop tourism hub

Nikhil Ghanekar
New Delhi, July 8

THE UNION Ministry of Ports, Shipping and Waterways has proposed protection and development works at Indira Point and the famous lighthouse at the site in the Andaman and Nicobar Islands. Through the Directorate of Lighthouses and Lightships, Sri Vijaya Puram (formerly Port Blair), an agency under the ministry, the Centre has sought coastal regulation zone clearance to carry out the proposed work.

Indira Point is India's southernmost tip, located on the Great Nicobar Island (GNI) in the Union Territory (UT) of the Andaman and Nicobar Islands. It is an important maritime landmark, and lies to the south of the Galathea Bay, where a transshipment port has been proposed under the GNI mega infrastructure project.

The government proposal

The Ministry of Ports, Shipping and Waterways, through the Directorate Gen-

eral of Lighthouses and Lightships, wants to structurally repair and eventually develop tourism infrastructure and facilities around the lighthouse.

The Centre wants to strengthen the structure, the immediate site around it and along with it, it has proposed a string of development activities. After the visit of Union Minister of Ports, Shipping and Waterways Sarbananda Sonowal in late November 2023, the project was approved by the Central Advisory Committee of Aids to Navigation to "preserve and protect the lighthouse for its functional requirement for safety of mariners, rich legacy of region, for historic and cultural significant for future generations", as per the project's environmental impact assessment study.

As per a detailed project report by IIT Madras for the proposed development works, structural reinforcements will include repair and strengthening of the lighthouse tower's foundation, an all-weather approach road, shore protection works with break waters around the tower, power-

Maritime landmark

- The lighthouse at Indira Point is an important landmark on the Singapore-Colombo international maritime route and is used as a navigational aid.
- It also holds importance for safe navigation towards the Galathea Bay in the coming times, where a transshipment port has been proposed.

house, inspection and staff quarters, compound wall and internal pathways.

Separately, development activities for tourism promotion have been proposed. These include eco-tourism, convention centre, cafeteria, viewing tower, cycle tracks, and an international standard museum building as well as a memorial structure.

The need for protection

The works proposed fall in sensitive coastal habitats, which are protected under the Island Coastal Regulation Zone Notification, 2019. So, it needs prior approval from the UT's Coastal Zone Management Authority and the Environment Ministry. The notification provides a regulatory framework for protection of coastal stretches, marine habitats and livelihoods of fisher and other coastal communities across the group of islands.

The lighthouse structure has faced weathering. The structural issues it faces can also be attributed to the changes it faced during the December 2004 earth-

quake and tsunami. The 2004 natural calamity had a huge impact on the entire island group, causing uplift in some areas and land sinking in others.

The site where Indira Point is situated, specifically, faced permanent land subsidence at the time. Originally, the site of the lighthouse and associated structures was at a height of 3.5 m above mean sea level. When the earthquake and tsunami struck the island, the land sinking and the inland ingress of the sea engulfed the lighthouse tower while destroying quarters and huts around it. Scientists and authorities have estimated that the Nicobar islands sunk 2.04 m, thus submerging the lighthouse base and foundation in sea.

The geological and shoreline changes have exposed the foundation to seawater since 2004, extreme wave conditions during high tide, as per the IIT Madras assessment. The lighthouse also shows a 3.86° inclination or tilt, which was, however, not considered as a risk to its structural stability or safety.

• EDUCATION

India's engineering colleges are losing sheen in AI era: What a reset can look like



EXPERT EXPLAINS
RAJEEV KUMAR

FORMER COMPUTER SCIENCE PROFESSOR AT IITs KHARAGPUR & KANPUR, BITS PILANI, & JNU

INDIA'S AMBITION to become a global-tech powerhouse hinges on its ability to produce world-class engineers. From artificial intelligence (AI), semiconductors, and quantum technologies to advanced manufacturing, clean energy, and the digital economy, engineering talent will be the cornerstone of the country's next phase of growth and global competitiveness. Yet, why is engineering education — the very pipeline expected to power the AI revolution — steadily losing its sheen?

While the IITs and a handful of premier

public and private institutions continue to attract India's brightest students, a large segment of engineering colleges is witnessing decline. The trend is reflected in the All India Council for Technical Education (AICTE) placing 58 engineering colleges under "progressive closure" and discontinuing more than 950 engineering and technical courses during 2025-26. Progressive closure is typically invoked for persistently low admissions and failure to comply with quality norms.

The challenge is not that engineering has become less relevant; rather, the real crisis lies in the widening gap between the capabilities expected by a technology-driven economy and those delivered by a large section of India's engineering education ecosystem. Unless this gap is bridged, India's aspirations for global leadership could be constrained not by a shortage of opportunities but that of employable, high-quality engineering talent.

Shift in policy focus

Until the late 1990s, engineering education in India was largely confined to pub-

licly funded institutions such as the IITs, regional engineering colleges (now National Institutes of Technology, or NITs), a few state engineering colleges, and private institutions concentrated mainly in Maharashtra, Karnataka, and Tamil Nadu. Limited capacity made admissions highly competitive, leaving India with a persistent shortage of engineering graduates.

The global IT boom around the Y2K revolution saw surging worldwide demand for software professionals, triggering an unprecedented expansion of engineering education. Thousands of new colleges emerged across metropolitan, urban, and rural India.

At the same time, the Union government expanded the network of Institutes of National Importance (INIs) by establishing new IITs and Indian Institutes of Information Technology (IIITs) and upgrading the regional engineering colleges into NITs. Today, India has 79 INIs: 23 IITs, 31 NITs, and 25 IIITs.

As access widened, the policy focus shifted from expansion to excellence. While AICTE approval remained the statutory requirement for establishing and op-

erating engineering institutions and programs (except most INIs, which enjoy statutory autonomy), the National Board of Accreditation (NBA) introduced outcome-based accreditation to benchmark programme quality against global standards. Replacing the traditional input-based approach, the NBA's criteria were based on measurable learning outcomes, graduate attributes, continuous improvement, and industry relevance. Accreditation soon became a key prerequisite for programme expansion.

Survival and sustainability

The AI revolution, which gathered momentum in the mid-2010s, has fundamentally reshaped engineering education. As industry demand shifted rapidly towards computer science, AI, data science and allied disciplines, student preferences followed suit. Traditional branches such as mechanical, electrical, and related engineering saw sustained declines in demand. The AICTE's moratorium on new engineering institutions in 2020 (before its lifting in 2023) reflected this changing landscape.

The transition accelerated after the Covid-19 pandemic, when AICTE removed the requirement for NBA accreditation to increase student intake or introduce new programmes. Consequently, many reputed institutions expanded capacity in high-demand disciplines while rationalising seats in traditional branches. As admissions became concentrated in a relatively small number of institutions, hundreds of lower-tier colleges were left with severely depleted enrolments, eroding their financial viability.

India today has an approved undergraduate engineering intake of nearly 15 lakh seats, of which the IITs account for about 19,000, the NITs for about 25,000, and the IIITs for about 11,000. Yet, several thousand seats even in NITs and IIITs remain unfilled each year, while 20-40% of seats in many traditional programmes remain vacant.

The imbalance between student demand and institutional capacity has made survival increasingly difficult for a large segment of engineering institutions. For many, progressive closure is no longer merely a regulatory measure but an inevitable consequence.

The way forward

The next phase of engineering education must shift to one driven by learning, innovation, and employability. Curricula should be continuously aligned with emerging technologies such as AI, data science and cybersecurity, while preserving strong foundations in mathematics, science and core engineering. A transition from rote learning to competency-based education through project-based learning, interdisciplinary problem-solving and stronger industry-academia collaboration is essential.

Institutional performance should be judged not merely by infrastructure and faculty strength, but by graduate employability, research, innovation, startups, patents and industry engagement.

Transforming engineering education is no longer an academic reform — it is a strategic imperative. India already has islands of excellence in its IITs and a few top institutions; the challenge is to replicate these strengths across the broader ecosystem while enabling the orderly exit of persistently non-performing institutions.



Delhi, Jakarta and a rediscovery story

PRIME MINISTER Narendra Modi's bilateral meeting with Indonesian President Prabowo Subianto offers an opportunity to inject fresh momentum into a relationship that has experienced periods of remarkable warmth and prolonged neglect. Bonds were forged in the shared anti-colonial struggle and both countries co-hosted the 1955 Bandung Conference that laid the foundations of the Non-Aligned Movement. They drifted apart, however, during the Cold War. India and Indonesia have steadily rediscovered each other since, as strategic partners. A rapidly rising China, and the risks of relying on US security under a mercurial president, provide the propulsive force for closer Delhi-Jakarta ties.

Defence, critical minerals, and maritime security have emerged as principal areas of cooperation. The agreement to supply BrahMos supersonic cruise missiles and Astra air-to-air missiles to Indonesia underscores India's emergence as a credible defence exporter. India must make better use of Indonesia's abundant reserves of nickel and rare earth elements. This will require greater domestic capacity, sustained political attention and deeper participation by the private sector. But the most significant outcome is the decision to jointly develop Sabang Port, located near the northwestern entrance to the Strait of Malacca. The Strait is one of the world's busiest chokepoints, carrying around 23 million barrels of oil a day (around 21 million passed through the Strait of Hormuz daily before the war). No major economy is more dependent on it than China, with an estimated 80 per cent of its imported oil passing through it. New Delhi has done well to deepen its partnership with Jakarta in securing its integrated development. The challenge, however, lies in implementation. A joint task force on Sabang has been there since 2018, but bureaucratic delays and financing constraints have kept the project from taking off.

PM Modi's meeting with President Prabowo follows his recent engagements with the leaders of South Korea and Japan, and will be followed by visits to Australia and New Zealand. Together, these engagements reflect a renewed vigour in India's Act East Policy and a recognition that deeper cooperation between the Indo-Pacific's middle powers can generate mutual economic and strategic gains while reducing the risks of excessive dependence on Washington or Beijing. India must match its external outreach with faster domestic reforms. Only a more competitive economy and a stronger defence industrial base will enable it to shape the emerging Asian order in accordance with its national interests.

When corruption does not make a political noise

THE STENCH of widespread corruption once again wafts over Indian public life. Whether it is repeated examination leaks, shoddy road construction, allegations surrounding contracts, the awarding of environmental clearances, the capture of regulatory agencies, theft from temples, expropriation of private companies, or abuse of public office for real estate deals, a familiar litany of complaints is gathering unprecedented momentum. At issue is not whether any specific claim is true. After all, many of the charges against UPA-II were never proved in a court of law. What matters is the pervasive sense of institutional corruption. The most telling sign is that even some supporters of the government acknowledge the problem.

Yet there is a striking paradox. Precisely at the moment when corruption has once again become the dominant idiom of public life, the prospects for a credible anti-corruption movement have become more remote. The Cockroach Janta Party, still protesting at Jantar Mantar, is animated by the admirable conviction that Indians need not simply roll over in the face of arbitrary power. But converting widespread moral unease into an effective political movement is far harder today than at any point. This widening gap between the visibility of corruption and the weakness of anti-corruption politics is not accidental. It points to deeper transformations in Indian politics.

Corruption, of course, never disappeared. But it receded from political consciousness. Its character appeared to change. Corruption seemed less retail than wholesale. It was less about the routine extraction that citizens encountered in

everyday dealings with the state, and more about discretion over high-level regulation, contracts, natural resources at the highest levels. The consequences of this corruption are not as easily felt. Second, improvements in state capacity and service delivery blunted everyday grievances.

Across party lines, welfare schemes became more effectively administered, many citizen-facing services were digitised, and the daily experience of many schemes improved. Third, the BJP-RSS combine successfully cast itself as the insurgent force confronting a corrupt Congress *ancien régime*. It appropriated the language of moral renewal. Finally, there was the political capital of Prime Minister Narendra Modi himself. His carefully cultivated image of personal integrity, the purity of his *neeyat* rather than his actual performance, created a widespread belief that, whatever the failings of others, the Prime Minister remained incorruptible and firmly in command. That moral authority, more than any institutional reform, helped mute corruption talk.

All four pillars have now collapsed. The ubiquity of exam scams, the pervasive and increasing shoddiness of public services in urban India, even the return of bad roads, disappointment about a range of services, and open talk of corruption in universities have made the retail-wholesale distinction less relevant. Citizens are feeling it more. At the same time, anxieties about high-level corruption have acquired a different character.

During the UPA years, one could plausibly argue that even serious corruption at the top need not permanently damage the



PRATAP BHANU MEHTA

economy so long as markets remained broadly competitive and no single group could systematically capture the state. Today, the concern is more profound. The fear is not simply that political power is being used to extract rents, but that it is being used to create and protect quasi-monopolies, selectively rewarding favoured firms while disadvantaging rivals. Corruption no longer merely "greases the wheels". It is this possibility, the fusion of concentrated political power with concentrated economic power, that makes concerns about corruption resonate even within sections of the private sector that had once regarded it as a manageable cost of doing business. Simply put, it is not that the cost of your business is high; your business is not even safe.

The political pillars have collapsed even more. The BJP and RSS are now wide tents, having incorporated, in the quest for power, most of the non-BJP actors they castigated as corrupt. The RSS is discovering that corruption is not just a matter of homilies about character; people with a background in the RSS can succumb to the temptations of unchecked power like anyone else. The allegations of temple theft in Ayodhya, an organisational structure architected entirely by the BJP-RSS, takes the figleaf off Ram Rajya, literally. The BJP is now the *ancien régime* with all the signs of rot too overwhelming to hide. Amongst some BJP supporters, there is still a residual belief in the Prime Minister's virtue. He is personally above the fray. There is even a theory doing the rounds: This rise in corruption talk is the Prime Minister's own master-

stroke, an attempt to delegitimise particular ministers and officials in his own party so he can act against them.

The problem with this theory is that there is no evidence that the Prime Minister will act against significant political players. At best, you will get small fry being sacrificed. The first strategy buys the Prime Minister's innocence, but by making him look weak. The issue is not the PM's virtue. Manmohan Singh was a saint by comparison, and he did not even control his party. But his abdication mattered. The strongest government in decades appears strangely powerless before the one problem it once claimed it was uniquely capable of addressing: Corruption. When the extraordinary power that the Prime Minister has encounters extraordinary silence and inaction on the issue of corruption, it tells a story. A very damning story.

The exposure of the government will not easily translate into a social movement. After the disillusionment with the AAP, the scepticism about movements is higher. It is also hard to find a focal point for a movement; the Opposition cannot claim the moral high ground. At the moment, there is no major elite defection to amplify the concerns of ordinary people. From Bofors to 2G, elite and media amplification was a necessary condition for creating an effective movement. This the BJP still manages to control and suppress effectively. But those expecting the PM to do a clean-up will be disappointed. The silence and abdication are likely to be followed by more repression, not a real cleaning of the stables.

The writer is contributing editor, The Indian Express

The fear is not simply that political power is being used to extract rents, but that it is being used to create and protect quasi-monopolies, selectively rewarding favoured firms while disadvantaging rivals

For better cities, go with the water flow



KAUSHIK DAS GUPTA

UNTIL EARLY June, several parts of Mumbai were gripped by water shortage, with concerns mounting that the levels in reservoirs were dangerously low. Barely a week later, the city's anxieties have been turned on their head. Relentless monsoon rain has submerged roads, inundated homes, disrupted suburban rail services, and exposed the vulnerability of neighbourhoods built on low-lying land.

Maharashtra's capital receives around 2,400 mm of rainfall annually; by no stretch of the imagination can it be called water-poor. The city's annual swing between thirst and flooding is actually a commentary on the utilitarian imagination of water in urban India: As a resource to be extracted during the dry months and an inconvenience during the monsoon. What has virtually disappeared is the understanding of water as an integral part of ecological systems.

In *Unruly Waters: How Mountains, Rivers and Monsoons Have Shaped South Asia's History*, historian Sunil Amrith argues that the Subcontinent's relationship with water has long been marked by a desire to engineer it — by damming rivers, reclaiming wetlands, embanking floodplains and straightening channels. Such interventions increased food security and allowed people to build homes and create economic avenues. But water resists the certainties of conventional engineering. That areas such as Kurla, Sion and Hindmata in Mumbai — or TITO in Delhi or Bellandur in Bengaluru — are inundated whenever it pours speaks to water's enduring fidelity to geography.

For centuries, the landscape that became Mumbai functioned as a sophisticated natural water system. Marshes, mangroves, creeks, estuaries and wetlands absorbed rainfall, moderated tides and gradually released excess water into the sea. The city itself emerged from seven islands stitched together through successive reclamation projects. However, as Mumbai expanded, it followed the trajectory that Amrith has traced. The result is that rainwater now has nowhere to go except into streets, homes and overburdened drains. Climate change has magnified these vulnerabilities. When intense rainfall coincides with tidal surges, stormwater cannot easily flow into the sea, causing it to back up into drains and low-lying neighbourhoods.

Mumbai's predicament is a manifestation of an urban planning philosophy that locates water in the binaries of a deluge and shortage. Delhi faces a severe groundwater crisis, while the river Yamuna is reduced to a trickle during the dry season. Bengaluru has witnessed the destruction of hundreds of interconnected lakes even as neighbourhoods alternate between water shortages and floods. Chennai lurched from an acute drinking water crisis in 2019 to devastating floods within a few years.

There is no doubt that Indian cities need to modernise their ageing drainage systems and install pumping stations. But, as urban planners in several parts of the world increasingly argue, that alone will not be sufficient. About two decades ago, Chinese landscape architect Kongjian Yu articulated a radically different vision of urban water management — one that sought to work with nature rather than overpower it. Instead of treating rainwater as an inconvenience, sponge cities seek to absorb, filter, store and gradually release it. Parks become temporary detention basins. Wetlands are restored rather than reclaimed. Green roofs reduce runoff. Permeable pavements allow rainwater to infiltrate the ground.

After the disastrous Beijing floods of 2012, China incorporated many of Kongjian Yu's ideas into its Sponge City programme. South Korea has also incorporated its principles into urban development, Singapore has integrated reservoirs, wetlands and parks into its urban fabric, while Curitiba in Brazil has preserved floodplains as public parks, breaking down the rigid divide between ecological assets and civic infrastructure. The concept of "blue-green" infrastructure is evident in Rotterdam in the Netherlands, Copenhagen in Denmark and Medellín in Colombia, while Rwandan capital Kigali's early efforts to strengthen groundwater resilience through flood-prevention measures have earned international recognition.

For India, the lesson is not to replicate any one such model but to rediscover a forgotten principle: The fates of places are intertwined with living hydrological systems. The sooner India's cities learn to plan with water rather than against it, the more resilient their future will be.

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The Ideas Page

THURSDAY, JULY 9, 2026

Deepening India-Japan partnership offers a powerful, constructive model



THAROORTHINK
BY SHASHI THAROOR

WHEN JAPANESE Prime Minister Sanae Takaichi was in Delhi last week, I was in Japan. There was no connection between the two trips, but we both had a common message: A stronger India-Japan relationship is imperative for both countries at this time of global turbulence.

The first official three-day visit of PM Takaichi for the 16th India-Japan Annual Summit (July 1 to 3) marked a major turning point for Indo-Pacific diplomacy, injecting a massive \$12.5 billion in fresh Japanese investment into infrastructure and manufacturing sectors, effectively transforming the alliance into an economic powerhouse. Takaichi's milestone visit yielded 129 MoUs, primarily driven by the India-Japan Joint Economic Forum, which hosted over 150 leading Japanese corporations looking to anchor their capital in India's expanding ecosystem. By establishing a comprehensive roadmap for resilient supply chains in critical technology sectors, including semiconductors, telecommunications, and critical minerals, the partnership actively seeks to reduce vulnerability to single-source global networks and external market disruptions.

The summit solidified deep defence co-operation by committing to joint manufacturing of advanced military hardware, introducing the first military hardware co-development project focussing on cutting-edge naval technology like the Unified Complex Radio Antenna masts, alongside advanced bilateral deliberations regarding the future co-production of *Mogami*-class stealth frigates. Coupled with wide-ranging agreements on high-level AI safety standards, digital development frameworks, and a clean energy initiative spanning proposals for large-scale green ammonia and a rollout plan for 1,000 regional biogas plants, the summit positioned the partnership as a significant, multifaceted geopolitical counterweight in the region.



ILLUSTRATION: C R SASIKUMAR

The structural alignment underscores that beyond trade and investment, the contemporary geopolitical reality demands that India and Japan build Asia's most trusted civilisational partnership, one rooted in shared history, values, and democratic systems. At a historical moment when democracies worldwide are under stress, India and Japan stand as unique anchors of stable democratic governance in Asia, collectively representing one-fifth of humanity living under the rule of law. The strategic alignment formalised via the Quad is not a military alliance but a civilisational commitment to a free, open, and rules-based Indo-Pacific that respects national sovereignty and institutional resilience. By combining their voices, both nations are building an alternative blueprint for global governance, proving that technological progress, environmental sustainability, and commitment to human values can coexist within a fractured global order.

This civilisational cohesion finds an immediate practical application when addressing the stark demographic contrasts that define both societies. While their demographic trajectories appear diametrically opposed, they present an opportunity for complementarity. Japan faces an unprecedented demographic contraction, marked by a shrinking labour force and an ageing society that places severe stress on healthcare systems, hospitality, and technological management. Conversely, India continues to experience expansive demographic growth, with millions of young, technically literate citizens entering the workforce annually but facing unemployment. A hol-

istic, long-term talent and mobility collaboration can transform this contrast into shared economic benefits. By pairing Japan's acute labour shortages with structured, multidisciplinary talent-acquisition frameworks, Indian professionals can contribute substantively to Japan's socio-economic security. This arrangement must transcend short-term, myopic migration; it demands an immigration policy framework that prioritises cultural orientation, and robust institutional support to protect workers while delivering highly specialised care and management to Japan's silver economy.

This demographic synergy forms the cornerstone of what must become a joint India-Japan care economy. As Japan navigates its post-industrial demographic transition, it has pioneered sophisticated models of eldercare, rehabilitative robotics, and age-appropriate infrastructure. In the coming decades, India will paradoxically house one of the world's largest elderly populations alongside its youthful workforce, rendering Japan's current domestic challenges an essential preview for our future. Through joint venture initiatives, research-based collaborations, and knowledge transfers, India can proactively draw inspiration from Japanese models to develop a sustainable care economy before ageing becomes an acute national crisis.

An equally transformative dimension of this partnership lies in expanding female labour force participation. By designing structured pathways for Indian women to access certified training and deployment in Japan (under guaranteed conditions of safe housing,

career progression, and harassment-free workplace protocols), both nations can simultaneously address Japan's care vacuum and advance female inclusion within India's domestic workforce.

The bridge between these demographic initiatives and industrial durability lies in the integration of Japanese hardware excellence with Indian digital innovation. Celebrated for its peerless precision engineering, robotics, and advanced manufacturing, Japan possesses the material solutions to the physical supply-chain problems of the 21st century. India, conversely, has demonstrated global leadership in developing expansive digital public infrastructure, scalable software architectures, and highly adaptable AI applications. The two nations can co-develop next-generation assistive technologies, smart medical devices, and automated logistics networks. This synthesis ensures that economic growth remains anchored in real-world productivity, creating resilient industrial clusters that can insulate both nations from external supply shocks.

The true measure of the India-Japan partnership will be its capacity to foster an inclusive economic paradigm that prioritises the expansion of a stable middle class. India's developmental vision cannot be measured solely by GDP; true prosperity requires an egalitarian framework where the benefits of growth are democratised. In this pursuit, Japan's post-war economic miracle serves as the ultimate inspiration, demonstrating that enduring national stability and prosperity emerge when economic policies strengthen ordinary citizens. By shifting the focus of economic cooperation towards manufacturing hubs, logistics networks, and technological infrastructure in Tier-2 and Tier-3 cities, India can replicate Japan's success in driving regional balance and upward social mobility.

As India and Japan step forward into an era defined by global uncertainty, my visit convinced me that our deepening alliance offers a powerful, constructive model for the world: Proof that two great civilisations can align their economic security, demographic strategies, and technological futures to build a more stable, equitable, and democratic Indo-Pacific.

The writer is a fourth-term Member of Parliament (Lok Sabha) for Thiruvananthapuram and chairman of the Parliamentary Standing Committee on External Affairs

The true measure of the India-Japan partnership will be its capacity to foster an inclusive economic paradigm that prioritises the expansion of a stable middle class



URVASHI B SINGH

EVERY YEAR, more than 26 lakh Indians are diagnosed with TB. The conversation that follows is almost always about which drugs, for how long, and whether the strain is resistant. I have witnessed patients with an accurate diagnosis and drugs lose ground, week by week, because a body without adequate nutrition cannot fight this disease. We have shortened treatment regimens, extended social support to patients on treatment and tracked the treatment journey in real time digitally. In the Indian context, research shows that a severely undernourished TB patient is four times more likely to die during treatment.

India has not ignored this critical overlap. The TB Mukta Bharat Abhiyaan has made a meaningful conceptual shift: Individuals with a BMI below 18.5 are identified as vulnerable and prioritised for TB screening and offered X-rays — even for those without symptoms. Once a person is diagnosed with TB, tailored and individualised care is built into the treatment pathway.

Since 2018, the Nikshay Poshan Yojana has provided direct cash transfers to every notified TB patient, a benefit doubled to Rs. 1,000 per month two years ago, with over Rs. 4,590 crore disbursed to 1.39 crore patients till March. Over 7.16 lakh Nikshay Mitras, including citizens, corporates, and community organisations, have stepped forward with food baskets (for both the patient and the family) and psychosocial support for patients. On this count, India is

ahead of most countries. The government has also committed to providing energy-dense nutritional supplements (EDNS) to undernourished patients. A trial conducted in Faridabad found that TB patients who received energy-dense nutritional supplements were twice as likely to gain the weight they needed in the first two months of treatment, and patients who do not gain that weight are far more likely to face treatment failure and death. Providing nutrition support to patients with a BMI of less than 18.5

In the Indian context, research shows that a severely undernourished TB patient is four times more likely to die during treatment

could benefit nearly half of all diagnosed TB patients in India each year.

The next frontier is addressing the condition that makes people vulnerable to TB in the first place. According to the WHO, undernutrition is the single largest risk factor for TB globally. The evidence now is asking us to look at nutrition as a critical preventive strategy. A modelling study in The Lancet Global Health this year found that eliminating undernutrition could prevent one in four adult TB cases globally, with India standing to gain the most. The authors argue that current estimates of undernutrition's role in driving TB have been underestimated. The findings are a challenge to how we prioritise our TB prevention response.

The new evidence also validates what we have known by instinct, and an argument for scaling nutrition as a preventive

strategy with greater urgency: Find people who are undernourished and at elevated TB risk, provide meaningful nutrition support and counselling. The benefits extend beyond TB and reduce vulnerability to a wide range of infectious and non-infectious diseases, making the case for nutrition as a foundational public health infrastructure.

TB is a disease of circumstance as much as infection — that includes what and how much people eat. The commitment to nutritional supplementation during treatment is already on the books; the evidence for prevention is now impossible to ignore. A commentary in The Lancet put it aptly: Food is the tuberculosis vaccine we already have.

The writer is professor & in-charge, Tuberculosis Division, Department of Microbiology, AIIMS Delhi

REVAMPED SYSTEM TO ENABLE CENTRALISED DATABASE MERGING DATA FROM REGIONAL CENTRES

New EPFO portal to automate interest credit, streamline claims

Ravi Dutta Mishra & Aanchal Magazine
New Delhi, July 8

THE EMPLOYEES' Provident Fund Organisation (EPFO) has launched a revamped portal with a centralised database by merging information across all regional offices. The portal enables automated processes, including crediting of interest, claim verification and informing members about the amount they are eligible to withdraw, aimed at reducing claim rejection rates.

Labour and Employment Minister Mansukh Mandaviya on Wednesday said the interest of Rs 1.44 lakh crore for financial year 2025-26 will be auto-processed on the new portal and verified by field authorities before being credited to 34 crore EPF accounts by July 15.

"Field verification is currently ongoing to ensure that any account does not receive incorrect interest. After the process is over, over 34 crore EPF accounts will receive interest worth over Rs 1.44 lakh crore by July 15. Earlier, interest credit used to happen in October or November after the rates were

announced," Mandavaya said at a press briefing.

This comes after the Ministry of Labour and Employment implemented the CITES (Centralised IT Enabled Services) project, an initiative to modernise EPFO's service delivery through automation and rule-based processing. The ministry said the project is designed to improve EPFO's operational efficiency.

"Before CITES, EPFO had a decentralised architecture with separate databases at each field office. CITES has now enabled a single centralised architecture with one national database. EPFO has completed the process of migrating its entire database of member records to the new centralised database. Earlier, the services were tied to a particular regional office. Now, a member's service request can be processed from any authorised location across the country," Mandavaya said.

This centralised database will be helpful for employees who move across cities during their employment. For instance, if an employee has worked in Chennai and moves back to their hometown in West Bengal,

• SMART PROCESSING

THE INTEREST of Rs 1.44 lakh crore for FY2025-26 will be auto-processed on the new portal and verified by field authorities before being credited to 34 crore EPF accounts by July 15.

THE CENTRALISED database will be helpful for employees who move across cities during their employment.

THE PORTAL will show the eligible amount for withdrawals to members under the different claim categories. Member claims



will undergo automated pre-validation before processing at EPFO offices, and any deficiencies or discrepancies will be identified and communicated to members through SMS and the portal.

they will be able to access their records and resolve any issues at the EPFO office in West Bengal instead of travelling to the Chennai regional office.

The ministry said claim payments will be processed through a centralised payment architecture and routed through faster electronic payment channels, ensuring secure, efficient and timely credit of settlement amounts directly into members' bank accounts on the day of settlement.

"Under the revised system, interest on final PF settlements will now be calculated up to the date of payment authorisation. Earlier, interest was calculated only up to the last day of the previous month. This ensures that members receive the benefit of additional interest for the intervening period," a statement said. The EPFO's Central Board of Trustees had recommended an interest rate of 8.25% for financial year 2025-26 in March, which was ratified by the Min-

istry of Finance last month.

In the new portal, members will be able to view their membership details, provident fund balances, claim status, pensionable service records and benefits availed. This, the ministry said, will ensure transparency and provide access to information about their PF accounts and claim submissions. "Earlier, members' information was not available on a unified portal and remained scattered across different systems," the ministry said.

Member claims will undergo automated pre-validation before processing at EPFO offices, and any deficiencies or discrepancies will be identified upfront and communicated to members through SMS and the portal, helping reduce claim rejections and improve first-time acceptance rates. "Members will also be able to know what the eligible amount is, which they can apply for withdrawal from their PF account under the different types of withdrawals permitted and can make informed choices," the statement said.

FULL REPORT ON
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IMF lowers global growth forecast to 3%, India's to 6.4%

Siddharth Upasani
New Delhi, July 8

THE INTERNATIONAL Monetary Fund (IMF) on Wednesday lowered its global growth forecast for 2026 by a marginal 10 basis points (bps) to 3% on the assumption that the Strait of Hormuz begins re-opening in mid-July and the situation broadly returns to prewar state by March 2027 — even as US President Donald Trump said he thinks the ceasefire with Iran is over.

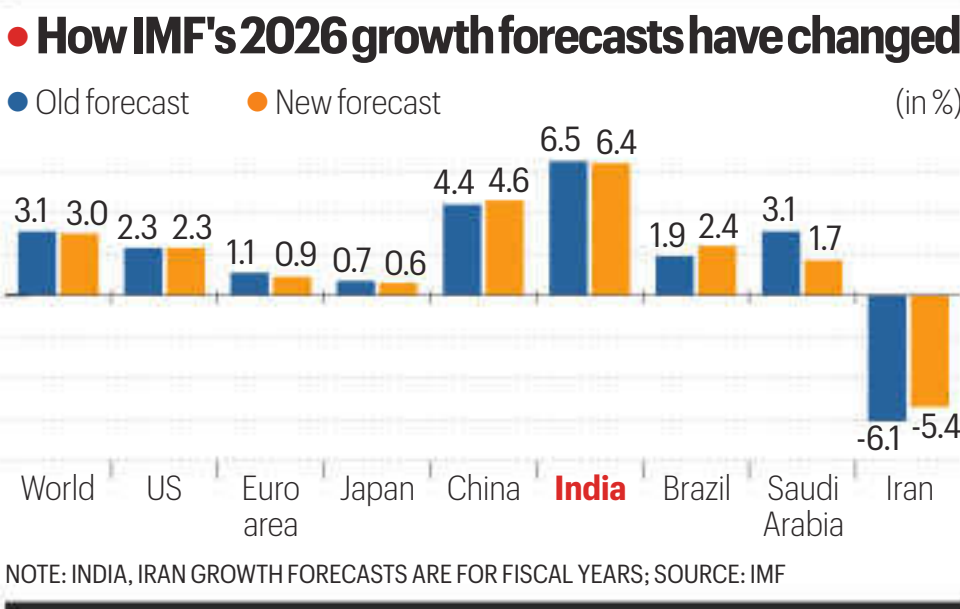
On Wednesday, Trump said the ceasefire was a "just a waste of time". Hours earlier, the US hit over 80 Iranian military targets after merchant ships were attacked in the Strait of Hormuz, with Washington also revoking a license that authorized the sale of Iranian oil.

While released on Wednesday at 6:30pm India time, the IMF's economic projections were prepared earlier.

"The most imminent risk to the baseline forecast stems from developments in the Middle East," the IMF said in a quarterly update to its World Economic Outlook report.

"Renewed conflict would propagate through a further increase in commodity prices and extended volatility, supply shortages, and exchange rate pressures. The muted increase in oil prices and their contained impact on activity owe to the release of inventories, which are now getting closer to multi-year lows and could reach stress levels should supply disruptions persist or hoarding gather steam," the multilateral agency added.

The tentative ceasefire helped placate markets across the world after the start of the conflict on February 27 led to a sharp rise in global energy prices



following the closure of the key waterway, Strait of Hormuz. The price of India's crude oil basket, which had surged 66% from February to \$114.48 per barrel in April, has cooled sharply to \$68.62 so far in July, according to petroleum ministry data.

However, the renewal of hostilities by the US has already begun to weigh heavy on financial markets and investors, with benchmark Indian equity indices slumping more than 2% on Wednesday. In line with the trimming of the global growth forecast, the IMF on Wednesday slightly lowered its projection for India's GDP growth in 2026-27 — also by 10 bps — to 6.4%. This is lower than the Reserve Bank of India's forecast of 6.6%.

"India remains among the fastest growing major economies, with growth projected at 6.4%, supported by strong momentum in private consumption and services activity," the agency said, even as it raised the forecast for 2027-28 by 20 bps from April to 6.7%. In calendar year 2026, the IMF sees India's GDP growing 7%, before cooling to 6.4% in 2027.

China, meanwhile, got a 20-bps bump-up to 4.6% for 2026 and 10 bps for 2027 to 4.1%. Brazil, meanwhile, is seen growing half-a-percentage point faster

than previously thought this year at 2.4%. In the West Asia region, the IMF expects Saudi Arabia's economy to expand by 1.7% in 2026, down from its forecast of 3.1% in April.

"Iraq, Kuwait, and Qatar — commodity producers most affected by disruptions to energy output and transport — are projected to experience sharp contractions of their economies in 2026, followed by double-digit expansions in 2027."

Iran's economy is expected to shrink by 5.4% in its 2026 fiscal year.

According to the IMF, the world economy has, so far, weathered the shock from the US-Israel-Iran war "better than feared". Global growth is seen slowing only modestly from 3.5% in 2024-2025 due to the hit from the conflict being "partly offset by accelerated demand-driven momentum in the global technology cycle thanks to advances in artificial intelligence (AI) and its adoption".

Commodity prices, however, remain elevated, the IMF said, with energy prices around 25% higher than prewar levels. This, along with higher inflation numbers, have raised inflation expectations.

FULL REPORT ON
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Hormuz flare-up exposes fragility of US-Iran MoU, keeps oil market on edge

Sukalp Sharma
New Delhi, July 8

WITH A few energy tankers coming under attack near the Strait of Hormuz on Tuesday, cracks have appeared in the fragile ceasefire that took effect about three weeks ago with the signing of the US-Iran MoU. The US responded to the Iranian attacks on the tankers by striking over 80 Iranian military targets, including air defence systems, command and control networks, coastal radar sites, anti-ship missile capabilities, and more than 60 Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps (IRGC) small boats. Iran then claimed that it launched retaliatory strikes against US assets in countries like Bahrain and Kuwait.

The global energy market, which had just started to breathe easy over the past few weeks as maritime traffic via the Strait of Hormuz showed clear signs of recovery, is on the edge again. Oil prices shot up amid the renewed tensions. As of Wednesday evening, Brent futures were nearing \$80 per barrel, up over 7%. The stress is understandable, as the West Asia war and the effective closure of the Strait of Hormuz, which usually sees the transit of a fifth of global oil and LNG flows, led to one of the worst energy supply crises ever.

Will the recent flare-up be contained, or will it again expand into a wider conflict, and what will be the fate of oil and gas flows through the Strait of Hormuz — these are the key questions on everyone's mind. How the situation evolves hereon will be a major factor in the oil price trajectory; prices had touched multi-year highs of well over \$100 per barrel amid the supply disruption. The crisis was particularly trying for large Asian importers of energy, in-

• STRAIT TENSIONS

BRENT FUTURES rose to \$78 per barrel, up nearly 6%, on Wednesday afternoon.

THE US has revoked its sanctions waiver for Iranian oil, which would effectively make Tehran's crude unpalatable for most of the world, except for perhaps China.

cluding India, as a bulk of the oil and gas flows that transit the strait are consumed by Asian economies.

Meanwhile, US President Donald Trump said that he thinks that the US-Iran MoU is "over", even as peace talks between Washington and Tehran continue. The US has also revoked its sanctions waiver for Iranian oil, which would effectively make Tehran's crude unpalatable for most of the world, except for perhaps China — a regular buyer of Iranian oil. While it may be too early to expect definitive answers to these questions, industry insiders and experts expect both the US as well as Iran to de-escalate and

avoid a return to the full-scale confrontation.

"Despite this being the worst exchange of fire between the US and Iran since the June 17 MoU and Trump's subsequent claims, the tentative ceasefire might still hold. Neither country would want to go back to full-scale conflict. Iran's targeting of the three ships transiting the Strait of Hormuz was perhaps to try to force vessels to use its new designated route. The strikes on Iranian coastal positions by the US were a warning of sorts. Iran's response, though, of loosening fire at Bahrain and Kuwait could signal that Tehran is willing to push the envelope more and embroil the region in tur-

moil again," an international energy and shipping expert told *The Indian Express*.

All eyes on Hormuz

The critical maritime choke-point of the Strait of Hormuz lies at the centre of the latest flare-up, as well as the resurfaced worries around the trade flows. The critical energy trade artery had been free for navigation prior to the war that began late February, but since then, Iran has been claiming sovereignty over parts of the narrow waterway between the country and Oman. During the war, Iran actively regulated the flow of vessels through the strait, allowing only a handful to pass, that too using routings dictated by it.

Following the June MoU with the US, Iran continues to insist that vessels should cross the strait only through the routings designated by it, and that too after seeking its permission. Tehran also plans to impose a service fee for transits, but at a later date. Iranian state television reported that the ships that came under attack on Tuesday were sailing outside the shipping lanes authorised by Tehran.

On the other hand, the US and its allies have been encouraging vessels to use the strait's waters hugging Oman as an alternative to Tehran-designated lanes. The stark differences in the MoU's interpretation and the vagueness in its terms have now emerged as the flashpoints in the uneasy ceasefire, as per market watchers.

"At the heart of the matter is that the MoU between the US and Iran included provisions aimed at reopening the Strait of Hormuz to commercial shipping, but it left important details on control and traffic management deliberately ambiguous," Tony Sycamore, market analyst at IG Australia, said in note.

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• DELINQUENCIES IN 180 DAYS-PAST-DUE CATEGORY HAS RISEN TO 8.1% FROM 5.8% FOUR YEARS AGO

Credit card boom accompanied by delinquencies, borrower stress: CIBIL

George Mathew
Mumbai, July 8

INDIA'S DECADE-LONG credit card boom is beginning to enter a more challenging phase. As millions of consumers embrace easy access to unsecured credit, rising delinquencies, increased borrowing across multiple loan products and emerging "pockets of stress" are pointing to evolving challenges for lenders and borrowers alike, according to a TransUnion CIBIL report.

While the industry has celebrated a sharp rise in credit card issuances — from 1.4 crore to 5.2 crore in ten years — and spending, the report says consumers are likely to hold multiple credit

cards and multiple unsecured products in their wallet, creating "distinct growth and risk opportunities for card issuers to manage effectively".

This is at a time when consumers juggle multiple card and credit products and younger borrowers enter the market with more aggressive borrowing habits. Outstanding credit card balances have surged more than eight-fold over the past decade to Rs 3.1 lakh crore, but the rapid expansion has also coincided with a deterioration in asset quality since 2022.

• RISING DELINQUENCIES

After a period of improving repayment behaviour before the pandemic (2016 to 2020), delin-



CIBIL said the share of consumers with three or more cards in their wallet has increased from 12% to 22%. REUTERS

quency levels have begun rising again. "Since 2022, as growth resumed, the system witnessed a rise in delinquencies alongside

stabilisation in balances, indicating 'pockets of stress' emerging within a rapidly expanding unsecured ecosystem," said CIBIL,

a credit information company registered with the RBI, in its white paper on credit cards.

Delinquency level in 180 dpd (days past due) category since 2022 has gone up from 5.8% to 8.1% in March 2026.

A significant shift is that credit cards no longer operate in isolation. "Cards are now part of a broader unsecured credit landscape. The share of open credit cards within unsecured credit products has declined over time, from 56% in 2016 to 38% in 2026," said CIBIL.

Card issuers are now "increasingly competing with small-ticket personal loans — loans below Rs 50,000 — and consumer durable loans for life-

style financing by consumers."

Consumers are increasingly using several credit products simultaneously rather than relying primarily on credit cards.

"Credit card consumers are more likely to hold multiple credit cards and multiple unsecured products in their wallet as compared to the last decade. The share of consumers holding other consumption-led credit in their wallet has doubled from 16% to 32% in the last decade," CIBIL said. It said the share of consumers with three or more cards in their wallet has increased from 12% to 22% during the same period. This growing overlap of products creates competing repayment obligations

and makes it harder for lenders to assess borrower risk using a single product in isolation.

• HIGH EXPOSURE USERS

Another worry is the emergence of "high exposure users," who account for around 10% of cardholders. High exposure users are known for high utilisation, use multiple unsecured credit products and have higher exposure to risk across wallets, it said. Consumers in this segment who missed two or more repayments across products were substantially more likely to become seriously delinquent on their credit cards than other customer groups. Delinquency worsens as highly leveraged borrowers gain more credit experience.

"Diversified credit users with 4 plus years of card experience have 40 to 60 bps higher delinquency than the overall delinquency for the persona," CIBIL said. Borrowers with multiple personal loans accumulated over recent years are particularly vulnerable.

"22% of consumers with 4 years plus card experience have opened more than three personal loans in the last 24 months and have delinquency of 8.7%," CIBIL said. Meanwhile, Gen Z consumers opened new unsecured loans post first card at a higher rate compared to millennials (those born between 1980 and 1994), it said. FULL REPORT ON
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